COUNTRY REPORTS: EGYPT

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Status report

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Governance

Strategies, plans and policies

A cabinet meeting on presidential directives in July 2026 framed Egypt's digital transformation as an instrument for protecting public funds, managing state assets and raising the efficiency of state institutions, and directed every minister to produce a digital-transformation delivery plan. That puts control of public money beside service delivery as the estate's stated purpose.

The governing instrument is unchanged. Digital Egypt, published by the communications ministry, covers first, middle and last mile connectivity, digital identification, cybersecurity, e-commerce, payments, e-government services, digital market regulation, postal services, mobile wallets, broadband and artificial intelligence. Above it, digital transformation is one of the seven enablers of Egypt Vision 2030, which calls for seamless connectivity between the databases of government entities. The World Bank records a current transformation strategy in force rather than expired, with a companion instrument in the same family still planned or in draft (2025).

Delivery is being pushed down to the governorates. The FY2026/27 development plan uses integrated population databases to assess governorate performance and to tie incentives to the results each governorate achieves on the population file. Nothing published about that arrangement establishes what the incentives are, who sets the governorate targets, what a governorate gains or loses, or what safeguards attach to a system measuring fertility and marriage at population scale (August 2026).

The record the strategies are written against is middling and patchy. Egypt scores 51.0 out of 100 for overall governance in the 2024 Ibrahim Index, 24th of 54 African states and just above the African average of 49.3, having improved 3.0 points over 2014–2023, but it is above the continental average on only 42 of the index's 96 indicators, and has no data at all for 14 of them (2023).

Legislation and regulation

The chair of the House of Representatives' ICT committee said in October 2026 that a digital-safety bill, most of it regulating children's use of social media, heads the committee's agenda for the new session, after the telecoms regulator said in September that it was preparing a comprehensive digital-safety law with the committee, to cover dangerous games and betting apps as well as social platforms; no draft has been published. The work follows the Cabinet's agreement on 29 July 2026 to open a legislative review of the statutes governing social media, with increased financial penalties among the changes under consideration. At that meeting the ICT minister said that a unit inside the telecoms regulator already detects and deals with AI-manipulated video and images, and legislative amendment is needed to confront the practice at root, and nothing has been published about that unit — no name, legal basis, size, detection method or route by which a detection can be contested. Parliament is divided: the

communications committee deputy holds that the existing IT-crimes law needs only limited amendments and that the real gap is enforcement, while a Senate bloc leader presses for a minimum platform-use age modelled on Australia, the UK, Japan, China and the UAE.

What is on the books is older and thinner. The Telecommunication Regulation Law No. 10 of 2003 is the governing instrument for universal access, spectrum management and telecoms regulation; and the National Elections Authority law of 2017 requires state agencies to share data with the Authority. Digital identity has no instrument of its own, the framework assembled from the Civil Status Law No. 143 of 1994, the data protection law and its executive regulations, Financial Regulatory Authority fintech decrees 139-141 of 2023, the Cybercrime Law No. 175 of 2018, the telecoms law, the Anti-Money Laundering Law No. 80 of 2002 and the 2014 Constitution's privacy guarantee. There is no right to information law in force, and the promised tax-refund window still awaits legislation.

The Financial Regulatory Authority's Decision No. 2735 of 2026 gives consumer and small-business finance companies two months to verify customers by one-time password (September 2026). Its sandbox has received 49 projects, granted 7 preliminary approvals and cleared 2 into three-month renewable live testing, while giving regulatory guidance to 45 entities (August 2026), and neither cleared project is a payments product. Under Board Resolution No. 51/2026, factoring companies must ensure no receivable is factored twice, using an electronic platform that lets them query an invoice before financing it.

Data protection

Enforcement of Egypt's Personal Data Protection Law is due to begin on 1 November 2026, at the close of the one-year compliance window opened by the November 2025 Executive Regulations — and three months out from that date the Personal Data Protection Centre was still running an awareness workshop on the law inside the Ministry of Social Solidarity. The law had sat five years without implementing rules before Ministerial Decision No. 816 of 2025 was issued on 1 November 2025, setting a licensing and permit regime for controllers and processors, cross-border transfers, electronic direct marketing and visual surveillance.

A joint decision of the Supreme Council for Media Regulation and the telecoms regulator, reported on 17 September 2026, bars social platforms from holding independent accounts for children under 13, makes a safe mode the child cannot switch off compulsory for those aged 13 to under 15, and requires age verification that collects no more data than it needs. The regulator says platforms have three months to comply, the rules reach existing accounts, and a platform that does not comply can be blocked in Egypt entirely; it also says tens of thousands of people subscribed in two months to the child online-protection services the mobile operators launched in mid-2026.

The Personal Data Protection Centre, established under Law No. 151 of 2020, is the supervisory authority: it licenses data processing, conducts inspections and acts against violations of the law, a position the Executive Regulations confirm. Some organisations must appoint registered data protection officers, and controllers must notify breaches within 72 hours — immediately where national security is implicated, with affected individuals told within three days of the authority. The regulations add safeguards for the processing of children's data, and transfers of personal data out of Egypt require a licence from the Centre. Individuals hold rights to give and withdraw consent, to obtain access to or a copy of their data, to correct and delete it, and to object to its processing.

The one substantial enforcement to date came from a court, not the regulator. The Alexandria Economic Court awarded EGP 10 million against Orange Egypt in February 2025 over an unconsented SIM swap, grounding the operator's liability in tort and "custodian's liability" rather than in the data protection law, which had no implementing rules at the time.

Around the statute the direction has been the other way: Egypt's Digital Freedom score fell 11.8 points over 2014–2023 to 16.6 of 100, 51st of 54 African states, and Rights is its second worst-performing governance sub-category, at 16.0 and 52nd of 54 in 2023. In July 2026 an MP put on record that the Cybercrime Law and the Penal Code are insufficient to protect digital privacy, and called for a standalone privacy statute. The centre opened its portal for accreditation, licence and permit applications in early October 2026, on a law firm's account.

Regional collaboration

Egypt was elected on 31 July 2026 to chair two of the six working groups of the Arab Permanent Committee for AI and Emerging Technologies — AI governance and quantum computing, and no text, budget or timetable has been attached to either remit.

The chairmanships cap a year of Egyptian hosting. The committee implements a resolution of the 29th session of the Council of Arab Ministers of Communication and Information, which Egypt hosted in January 2026, and held its first founding meeting at the communications ministry's own headquarters in May 2026. Its mandate is to propose regional and international agreements and to coordinate a unified Arab position in international forums.

Overland, the links are older: a 400-km fibre cable to Sudan opened in October 2004, and in April 2021 the incumbent signed an agreement with the Sudanese operator to carry international traffic over it and a memorandum with Libya's international carrier to upgrade the border cable to Libya. Where payment systems cross the border, the reach is one-directional. Inbound cross-border remittances have arrived instantly into accounts and wallets since December 2024, with bilateral links to other instant payment systems planned rather than live. The Central Bank casts its banking cooperation with Eswatini as part of a broader strategy of strengthening relations with African countries and supporting continental economic and financial integration, and reviewed its currency-circulation system and the capabilities of the Egyptian Currency Printing House with Eswatini's governor (July 2026) — Egyptian experience shared rather than a new link between systems.

Outside the region the ties are commercial and diplomatic rather than technical. Egypt's ICT minister and the British ambassador discussed in January 2026 widening ICT cooperation and drawing British firms into Egypt's offshoring industry, pitching Egypt as a regional hub and gateway to African markets, and Egypt and Japan co-chair a "Water and Planet" dialogue at the 2026 UN Water Conference.

Standards

Egypt's whole-of-government data governance arrangement is planned or in progress rather than in place, follows a multilevel approach, and sits inside another institution rather than in a body of its own, and the government interoperability framework is still in draft or planned while the platform it would govern is recorded as only partially used (2025).

What standardisation there is has been done service by service, at launch. The public-shop licensing service unified fees across the participating agencies, with the Interior Ministry cutting its own by 50%, and gave a single back-office body a binding maximum approval time; the service is also the first government service to reuse verified digital documents held in the digital treasury, whose first document was an employment registration certificate (July 2026). That is a standard for one service, negotiated once, rather than a framework any other service inherits.

The published standards Egypt is most visibly shaping are regional and non-binding. The Arab Charter for AI Ethics is a 59-page document dated July 2025, prepared by the Arab AI Working Group of the League of Arab States and adopted by the 29th session of the Council of Arab Ministers of Communication and Information, setting out six pillars carrying roughly forty principles — identity and belonging, ethical innovation, conscious use, flexible and effective governance, Arab integration and digital leadership, and comprehensive sustainability. It describes itself as

an advisory and guiding document that is explicitly not a substitute for national policy or binding regulation — which is the ceiling on the working group Egypt now chairs, remitted to produce a guidance framework for AI governance, technical tools, and mechanisms for activating that charter.

Internationally the national standards body has been Egypt's ISO member since 1957, participating in 190 technical committees and observing 203 (October 2026), and Egypt is a full member of the International Electrotechnical Commission.

Public debate and participation in policymaking

Security forces arrested the six journalists who make up the entire newsroom of the independent investigative platform Matsda2sh on 28-29 September 2026, and the Interior Ministry acknowledged the arrests on 1 October citing fabricated news, without naming charges. Blocking runs alongside arrest: at least 630 websites, independent media among them, were blocked in Egypt as at February 2026, and in April 2026 the media regulator moved to block the news site Egyptke permanently a day after summoning its legal representative, citing false news and licensing.

Participation is Egypt's worst-scoring governance sub-category: 14.3 of 100 in 2023, 49th of 54 African states after a 9.7-point fall over the decade, with the deliberative and participatory governance measure inside it down 11.3 points to 35.7. The channels themselves exist — a citizen participation platform is in use, with petitions carried on the same portal (2025) — which is a statement about plumbing rather than about civic space.

The conditions for arguing with the state are worse than the means of petitioning it. Egypt scores 0.0 for Freedom of Association and Assembly in 2023, the lowest score the index awards, 44th of 54 and down 12.5 points over the decade, and 8.2 for Civil Society Space, 51st of 54; Media Freedom stands at 16.4, 53rd of 54.

Nor are the records there to argue with. There is no right to information law in force, the legislation still in draft with consultations in progress (2025), and the ability to obtain state records in practice remains among Egypt's weakest measures.

What scrutiny there is comes through the press and the trade bodies rather than through consultation. Five years into the tax digitisation programme, practitioners told Al-Borsa that some tax offices still inspect from paper files and ask for documents already filed electronically or held on the authority's databases, and the federation of chambers of commerce running the awareness campaign for the new shop-licensing service is pressing publicly for every cost to be published and for no agency to levy new fees. Parliament's August 2026 debate on social media ran in the opposite direction, a committee deputy calling for the media regulator to adopt AI-based monitoring in place of human review so that offending content and accounts can be detected and closed immediately.

Finance

Financial sustainability

Egypt's 2026/27 budget raised the communications ministry headquarters' appropriation to 23.23 billion pounds from 19.70 billion in 2025/26 while its own resources shrank: other revenues of 5.67 billion pounds and grants of 397.3 million, 7.3 million of them capital grants from international organisations, against other revenues of 8.30 billion the year before.

The running costs sit on the ministry's own lines: its goods-and-services chapter rose to 5.08 billion pounds and its investment chapter to 17.77 billion for 2026/27, from 3.58 billion and 15.76 billion. The statistics agency CAPMAS was appropriated 3.63 billion pounds for 2026/27, 3.29 billion of it investment, against 2.16 billion in 2025/26. No outturn against the digital appropriations had been published as at September 2026.

The domestic-state share of the digital lines read was 99.98% at the appropriated stage in the 2026/27 budget, as in 2025/26, the only external money printed being 7.3 million pounds of international grants. Net of its own revenues and grants, treasury financing of the ministry headquarters rose from about 11.39 billion pounds in 2025/26 to 17.17 billion in 2026/27.

The identity system's development fund carries no treasury money: the Civil Status System Development Fund finances its whole 2.26 billion pound budget for 2026/27 from its own revenues, with no treasury money, grants or borrowing, up from 1.73 billion in 2025/26. On the new E-Court platform part of the charge goes to a private provider: the justice ministry says the E-Court platform's text-message service is paid to the company contracted to provide it, not to the ministry, and that a digital case file costs what the paper copy did, 150 pounds for the first 50 pages (September 2026).

MoUs and other agreements

The Central Bank of Egypt and Afreximbank signed a memorandum of understanding on 29 December 2025, between Governor Hassan Abdalla and Afreximbank President George Elombi, to establish a gold bank programme in Egypt — an internationally accredited refinery, secure vaulting and associated trading services, sited in a designated free zone. It fixes no capital and no timetable, and Egypt's place as the hub turns on a feasibility study and the approvals that would follow it.

Elsewhere the pattern is the same. ITIDA has signed a memorandum with EY MENA for a regional IT outsourcing delivery centre in Egypt (July 2026), and institutional agreements were signed during the Egyptian water minister's visit to Japan (August 2026). None of the memoranda commits a party to a sum or a date; they record intent, and the money, the scope and the timing are left to instruments that have yet to follow.

New investments

The largest commitment on the record is the US$3.5bn spectrum agreement Egypt signed in February 2026 with Telecom Egypt, Vodafone Egypt, Orange Egypt and e& Egypt, releasing an additional 410 MHz and roughly doubling operators' holdings, money that runs from the operators to the state.

Private capital in 2026 has gone mostly to finance and AI firms. Blnk, a point-of-sale consumer lender, closed a raise combining equity led by Algebra Ventures with SANAD Fund for MSME and Endeavor Catalyst, and local-currency debt facilities from National Bank of Egypt, Suez Canal Bank and Bank Al Baraka Egypt (June 2026); the AI commerce startup Fincart took a seed round co-led by Launch Africa Ventures and Antler MENAP (July 2026); and Synapse Analytics, which builds credit and risk decisioning software for financial institutions, raised a US$13m Series A led by Partech (September 2026). Konecta opened a regional headquarters in Cairo with its first global generative-AI centre of excellence (July 2026), and the National Telecommunications Regulatory Authority has licensed Hassan Allam Digital Infrastructure, developing with A15, to build a data centre on a stated US$400m first phase (2026). The payments-infrastructure operator eFinance agreed to buy the non-bank lender Tamweely for cash and new shares (August 2026). Not all of it has held: Telecom Egypt's board withdrew on 17 July 2026 from the agreed sale of a majority stake in its regional data-centre hub to Helios Investment Partners, the transaction's conditions unmet.

Development lenders fund the state's systems. The World Bank approved a US$400m loan in June 2020 for the Universal Health Insurance System, whose procurement module is in use while its beneficiary, provider and claims modules are not yet, and committed US$500m in December 2022 to expand the Takaful and Karama cash transfers and the social registry that targets them, US$326m of it disbursed by October 2025. The AIIB gave a US$200m partial guarantee on a Chinese-market bond whose proceeds go to digital infrastructure and green transport (2023), and the EBRD lent up to EGP 250m to Fawry's small-business finance arm under a youth credit line (April 2026). Under a fifth of the African Development Bank's court-automation grant was drawn: XDR 376,350.87 of a XDR 1,890,224.56 commitment had been disbursed against a project window that closed in 2022, for an automated case management system for the Court of Cassation and for capacity in the Ministry of Justice in legislative drafting and open rule-making.

Sixteen deal records are held for Egypt, fifteen of them with an amount, together about US$5.6 billion, dated from 2016 to 2026 and eight of them to 2026. The February 2026 spectrum award is US$3.5 billion of the total, so connectivity takes about two-thirds of the value; data storage, at about US$0.9 billion across five facilities, takes most of the rest. Five of the records are development-bank loans, grants or guarantees, together about a fifth of the value.

ICT Infrastructure

Connectivity

Egypt concluded a $3.5bn spectrum award to its four mobile operators in February 2026, releasing an additional 410MHz and roughly doubling the mobile spectrum in use in a single transaction. It followed commercial 5G, launched by the telecoms regulator in June 2025 and Telecom Egypt's $150m 5G licence of January 2024, and the minister has set a target of 40,000 mobile towers by 2028.

Coverage is close to saturated on the mobile side. 4G networks reached 98 percent of the population (2024), and cellular mobile connections equalled 97.3 percent of the population in January 2024 and 102 percent by October 2025. Fixed connections are far fewer, at 12.6 million fixed broadband subscriptions (November 2025), though Telecom Egypt's retail arm and Huawei launched fibre-to-the-room commercially in May 2026, the first such service in the country. Rural reach has come through the Decent Life programme's village fibre rollout. Beneath both, the incumbent completed replacing copper with fibre in the internet backbone in 2021, a project begun in 2014, and more than 18,000 of about 31,500 government buildings were on fibre in July 2023.

Internationally Egypt carries the largest concentration of submarine cable landings in Africa, and Telecom Egypt and Cisco partnered in January 2025 to operate capacity on the 2Africa cable's Mediterranean segment. Telecom Egypt's chief executive put its transit capacity above 330 Tbps, with more than 90% of Europe–Asia and Europe–Africa traffic passing through its infrastructure, and said the 200 km Sharm El Sheikh–Taba subsea cable agreed in September 2026 is expected to be ready for service late in 2027 (October 2026). Domestic traffic exchange runs through one active internet exchange point, EG-IX, with moderate participation.

Access is on closely identified terms: SIM registration is done in person against the original national ID card. The trajectory shows in the indices unevenly: Egypt's Internet & Computers score rose 24.3 points over 2014–2023 to 67.2 of 100, seventh of 54 African states and was its third most improved indicator of 96, while the mobile communications score moved 1.2 points over the same decade, to 75.5 and sixteenth.

Data Storage

Telecom Egypt's board withdrew on 17 July 2026 from the agreed sale of 75–80 percent of the unit owning its Regional Data Center Hub to Helios Investment Partners, saying the transaction's conditions had not been met, and will instead carve the hub out as a wholly-owned subsidiary; in October its chief executive said a dedicated entity had been established to develop the data-centre business — the largest domestic data-centre estate stays under a state-controlled operator. It sits alongside an integrated national data-centre strategy in preparation at the ICT ministry, ordered by presidential directive and framed on digital sovereignty and the localisation of data inside the country, aimed at making Egypt a regional hub for data storage and processing, which the minister said on 22 September 2026 will be launched by the end of 2026; the ICT ministry told Cabinet in July 2026 that it is expanding construction of giant data centres.

No general localisation rule sits behind that language. The Cloud First Policy adopted in 2024 governs government cloud adoption, and localisation under it applies to government data classified secret or top secret, rather than across the board; personal data is handled separately, through the authorisation requirement on cross-border transfers. Government's own workloads run on a private government cloud, hosted on a hybrid of facilities inside and outside government premises, across several platforms in central and local government (2025).

The commercial estate has grown fast, mostly through foreign vendors. Telecom Egypt's second regional data hub received Tier III design certification in November 2024, with an estimated IT load of 4.6 MW against 2.5 MW for its first. Huawei Cloud opened a public cloud region in Cairo in May 2024, on a $300m five-year investment. Domestic capital is entering: Hassan Allam Digital Infrastructure, with A15, holds a licence for a $400m first phase of hosting, cloud and AI-ready capacity (June 2026), one of several data-centre licences issued in two years, and Intro Group plans an 80 MW Tier III data centre in the Sokhna Industrial Zone of the Suez Canal Economic Zone, with nearly USD 270 million in the first phase, part of the engineering design complete and equipment supply contracts signed (September 2026). On 8 September 2026 Vodafone Business, Elsewedy Electric and Cassava Technologies announced Africa Data Centres Egypt at an initial 20 MW over three years, and Vodafone Business and Cassava a sovereign AI data centre offering NVIDIA-based compute as a service inside the country. Cooperation with SAP adds a European vendor track, its March 2026 talks aimed at cloud cooperation supporting Egypt's digital sovereignty over data and applications hosted on SAP platforms. Power sets the outer limit, which the frontier proposals answer directly: a hyperscale data centre for Sinai running on green hydrogen and solar with seawater cooling was under ministerial review in March 2026. An investment company's chief executive put installed data-centre IT load at about 15 to 20 MW, against 400 to 500 MW announced, of which about 20 MW is committed. The state digital-finance operator signed a memorandum with a Chinese cloud provider to explore offering its services to Egyptian businesses from locally hosted infrastructure (2026).

Energy

Firms reported an average of 0.8 outages a month, fewer than ten a year in the most recent enterprise survey, household access is effectively universal (2023), with no gap between urban and rural areas (2016), and Egypt takes a maximum 100.0 of 100 for Access to Energy on the Ibrahim Index, first of 54 African states (2023). Infrastructure is the country's best-performing governance sub-category in that index, at 83.2 of 100 and second of 54 after a 9.8-point decade rise (2023).

Price, not supply, is where the grid bites the household. The regulator's residential tariff is steeply tiered, from 0.68 EGP per kWh for the lowest bracket of 0-50 kWh to 2.23 EGP per kWh for homes using more than 1,000 kWh a month, under the schedule in force from September 2024, so a home that runs equipment continuously pays several times the rate of one that does not.

The generation mix moves more slowly than the connection figures. Renewables were a small share of electricity generation (2023). The regulatory frame around them has widened in the past two years: EgyptERA adopted a Smart Mini-Grids Regulatory Package in 2025, developed with the electricity ministry and the MENALINKS programme, setting licensing, tariff-setting and ownership rules for renewable mini-grids in remote areas and commercial, industrial and tourism clusters, and Circular No. 3 of 2023 sets licensing, capacity and periodic reporting rules for off-grid self-consumption solar, with a national cap of 1,000 MW. A government official said the electricity ministry had approved an EGP 3bn expansion of the El Alamein and Dabaa transformer zones, with two 500 kV substations, to serve data centres (October 2026).

Technical Capacity

GitHub recorded more than 990,000 developers in Egypt in 2024, up 25 percent year on year, a base large enough that the constraint on building systems in-country is not the supply of people who can write software.

Inside government the picture is narrower. The Civil Status Information Center provides the technical support for the national-number databases at the main centre in Abbasiya and the card production centre (2024), so the most sensitive register is run from premises in Egypt — but the biometric hardware behind it has come from the French vendor IDEMIA in partnership with the local firm AOI. The wider administration is the weaker half: the Ibrahim Index places Egypt's effective administration 44th of 54 African states (2023), within a public administration sub-category that fell over the decade while overall governance rose. The public service does have both a digital skills strategy and a skills programme, with free training reaching advanced data science (2025), yet the depth that has reached ministries is thin: three months before the data protection law's compliance window closed, the Personal Data Protection Center was still running an awareness workshop on the law inside a ministry (August 2026).

The pipeline behind both is steady rather than expanding. ICT graduates are a modest share of tertiary output, and teaching capacity has thinned over the decade even as enrolment and completion rose.

Cybersecurity

Egypt scored a maximum 100 of 100 on the ITU Global Cybersecurity Index for 2023-2024, placing it in the index's top tier. The governing document behind that is the National Cybersecurity Strategy 2023-2027, published by the ICT ministry.

The binding obligations on operators sit in data protection law rather than in a dedicated cyber statute. Controllers and processors must notify the supervisory authority of a personal data breach on a short statutory deadline, immediately where national security is implicated, and tell affected people shortly afterwards, and the executive regulations require some organisations to appoint registered data protection officers. Enforcement has started to appear in the courts: an Egyptian court awarded damages against a mobile operator in February 2025 over a SIM card replaced without the customer's consent.

The state is extending its operational reach faster than its assurance practice. The telecoms regulator runs a unit that detects and acts on AI-manipulated video and imagery circulating on social platforms, announced in July 2026; the ICT ministry is to certify the system, data-centre and security specifications for the 2027 census; and Egypt chairs the Arab AI Committee working groups on AI governance and on quantum computing, the second remitted to draft an Arab quantum-computing strategy and explore quantum-cybersecurity deployment. On the workforce, the National Telecommunications Institute's Cybersecurity SuperHero Academy, in its third edition, aims to train more than 6,000 people across 17 governorates free of charge, delivered with EG-CERT alongside Fortinet and Cisco (July 2026).

DPI

Data Exchange

The Financial Regulatory Authority's Decision No. 2684 of 2026, in force from 24 September 2026, requires consumer-finance companies to link their databases to the Authority's and to pass it customer records on approval of financing, customers' purchases in real time, their repayment standing and the firms' own solvency indicators, under controls the Authority is to issue within six months; the decision as announced sets no terms on customer consent, retention of the data or who may see it.

Egypt's government digital switch connected 105 government bodies, and a parallel data-integration effort had linked 100 national databases as at July 2026, while the framework meant to govern that exchange was still in draft and the interoperability platform itself recorded as only partially used in 2025.

The core of central government already moves data across a Government Service Bus — financial management, tax administration, customs, human resources, social insurance and debt management — alongside separate point-to-point interfaces (2025). Digital Egypt, run by MCIT, links government systems through shared platforms and networks (2025). The Unified National Registry, a World Bank-supported platform, connects 114 government databases through the national ID number and covers all Egyptian households (2022).

Where it works, it removes a step rather than adding a screen. GAFI issues a limited liability company's commercial registration, tax identification number, VAT registration and social insurance number together within one business day, with no separate approach to the tax authority, and the investment ministry's capital-increase platform links the eight government bodies a capital increase passes through, from the investment authority to the commercial registry and the central depository, passing data and procedures directly from one system to the next (September 2026). A link between the Public Prosecution and Interior Ministry traffic departments has ended the paper clearance certificate, and e-invoicing requires every document to carry either a company registration number or an individual's national ID number, binding tax records to the identity system.

Reach is thinner than the counts imply. The real estate registry's electronic integration with other bodies is concentrated in New Urban Communities Authority offices and pilot new cities rather than applied nationwide (2023), and inside the tax administration some tax offices ask taxpayers for documents already held on the authority's own databases (July 2026). The sharpest current test is a welfare payment: the ministries behind the Unified Government Services Card describe its technical work as integration and data-sharing mechanisms among participating government entities (August 2026), which makes the exchange layer the mechanism behind who eats.

Digital Identity and CRVS

Egypt's telecoms regulator said on 8 August 2026 that a mobile line registered in a person's name does not by itself establish that person's criminal responsibility for its use, after citizens using its own lookup found lines registered against their national ID without their knowledge, and a 19-year-old was sentenced in absentia to 25 years in a case involving a line registered in his name. The regulator's answer arrived within a week: it tightened the registration rules and referred all four mobile operators to the prosecution, while its chief executive presented the ministry's unified national digital-identity project alongside, and is expanding mandatory facial verification at enrolment through its know-your-customer system, linked to the civil registry. Verification at enrolment does not prevent a line being handed on afterwards, which is the gap the case turned on.

The answer was relaunching the "Arqamy" lookup inside the My NTRA app in August 2026 with mid-digit masking of the numbers shown, pending face-recognition login, and to offer a complaint route and a move to biometric subscriber verification. Both add identity assurance; neither reduces what rests on the register.

The card gates ordinary life. Registration is mandatory from age 15 under the Civil Status Law of 1994, and the national ID number is the civil registry's safeguard against fraudulent or multiple registrations (2025). Buying a SIM requires presentation of the original card; Takaful and Karama applicants are cross-checked against the Unified National Registry, which is keyed on the national ID, and Universal Health Insurance enrolment requires photo ID for every family member over 16; foreign residents must instead register with the passports and immigration administration for an ID card of their own to keep access to government services.

Several biometric front ends now check against that one register. The Central Bank launched Haweya in November 2025, a face-and-fingerprint eKYC app opening a bank account remotely at 37 banks, and its board approved the rules governing the digital financial identity in August 2026, letting customers take banking products through digital channels with electronic authentication in place of a handwritten signature; the Interior Ministry launched MOIEG-PASS in February 2026, scanning the card and matching the face before granting access to services; MCIT's own app added biometric verification and liveness detection in a second release by July 2026; and on 18 September 2026 the communications and interior ministries opened a biometric verification and electronic-signature platform to licensed mobile operators, so that services needing an identity check can be taken through the operators' own apps without a branch visit, in a trial period. Oversight is split to match — Haweya with the Central Bank, MOIEG-PASS with the Interior Ministry, and digital ID rules for non-bank finance with the Financial Regulatory Authority, whose Decree No. 140 of 2023 makes biometric verification mandatory for fintech transactions. Holding the number is becoming a precondition of due process: Bareedi, Egypt Post's digital postbox, is bound to the holder's national ID, and an August 2026 protocol makes its registered e-mail service a channel for judicial notices.

Digital Payments and Fintech

Financial inclusion reached 79% of the eligible adult population by June 2026, with 56.4 million people holding active bank, postal, wallet or prepaid-card accounts out of an eligible population of 71.4 million — a 229% rise since 2016.

The rail underneath is the Instant Payment Network, launched in 2022 and reached through the InstaPay app, giving 24/7 real-time interoperable transfers across bank accounts, mobile wallets and cards, owned, overseen and settled by the Central Bank and operated by its technical subsidiary the Egyptian Banks Company. InstaPay had about 22 million registered customers in the second quarter of 2026, by the end of which the network had recorded 1.47 billion transactions worth about EGP 4.33 trillion, and alongside it the telecoms regulator counted 57.01 million operator-run mobile wallets in the first half of 2026, up 23% in a year, transacting EGP 2.96 trillion, with 67% of them registered to men.

What that rail costs turns on a board decision rather than a statute. The Central Bank exempted individuals from all charges on electronic-channel Egyptian pound transfers from 1 January 2025 for three renewable months; from 1 April 2025 transfers have carried a fee of 0.1% capped at EGP 20, ending three years of free instant transfers. The rules are no more public: only the original October 2021 scheme rules were published, the current iterations being available to participating banks alone.

Acceptance is thickening — over 26,000 ATMs and roughly 275,000 point-of-sale terminals at the end of 2025 — and the Central Bank launched SoftPOS in February 2026 so a merchant can take contactless payments on an ordinary NFC phone. Inbound cross-border remittances have settled instantly into accounts and wallets since December 2024, and six Egyptian banks have applied to the Central Bank for final approval to connect InstaPay to the pan-African payment system (September 2026).

Government money runs on the same plumbing: e-Finance operates the government payments network and handles receipts including taxes, customs and social insurance contributions, and the pensions authority paid EGP 42bn of early-June 2026 pensions to 10.2 million beneficiaries through a digital system launched nationwide in February

2026. Across government, the finance ministry put electronic payments and collections at EGP 2.5tn for July 2023 to May 2024, up 19%. The Financial Regulatory Authority runs a digital factoring portal to stop the same invoice being financed twice (February 2026). Payment customers sit under a regime of their own: Law No. 194 of 2020 gives Central Bank licensees their own rules on customer protection and dispute settlement, and the general consumer protection law does not apply to them; the Central Bank's complaints-handling instructions of May 2024 set a 15-working-day reply limit binding banks, payment-service providers and their agents.

Registries

Fewer than 10 percent of Egypt's real estate is formally registered, though nearly 30 million National Property Identification Numbers have been issued (2026).

The machinery is being rebuilt on an identifier: a National Real Estate Identification System, under a law passed by the House of Representatives in 2025, gives each property a unique identifier, with about 19 million numbers issued across several governorates and executive regulations in preparation. The title register moves at another pace entirely: it is governed by Law 142 of 1964 and applied survey section by survey section, each section needing its own ministerial commencement decision, so there is no national completion date, and in a decision gazetted on 4 August 2026 the justice ministry deferred commencement for one survey section of Manshah, in Sohag, from 1 July 2026 to 1 July 2027, twenty-six years after that section was brought within the system.

The National Platform for Regularising State Lands had taken more than 302,000 applications under Law 168 of 2025 by 4 August 2026, against about 1,700 regularisation contracts drawn up.

That is a completion rate of roughly 0.6 percent on the applications received.

The population side is in a different condition. Birth, death, marriage, divorce and family registration databases are integrated into the national-number system, which also connects to external bodies from the traffic directorate and social insurance to the Central Bank. Electronic birth and death notification has run since 2017 at around 4,571 health offices, rural facilities included, which transmit to civil registry offices for compilation, and fewer than two million births were recorded in 2024, for the first time since 2007. The electoral roll is derived from that register rather than canvassed, and covered over 67 million voters at the December 2023 presidential election.

The commercial register is moving online without a published size: twenty registry services were online after six were added to Digital Egypt in July 2025, when tax-number verification for the register also moved online. Addresses have had a national seven-digit postcode for each group of buildings since 2020, built on the statistics agency's data, and in July 2025 the real estate registry was linked with the New Urban Communities Authority in 16 registry offices in the new cities. The Tax Authority runs a nationwide digital taxpayer registry keyed on a taxpayer identification number (2025), and the Takaful and Karama social registry holds around 11.3 million households, of which 4.67 million were enrolled in the transfer itself by December 2023.

Sectoral management information systems

Egypt's National Social Insurance Authority says its new system served 8,621,000 people in about four months to August 2026 and now both disburses pensions monthly and collects contributions, having paid 167,500 arrears cases and cleared 92% of an accumulated backlog as at 1 August 2026. The agriculture ministry's digital register of agricultural holdings ties each holding to the crop actually grown, across about 4.4 million farmer cards, to stop fictitious holdings and misdeclared crops being used to claim subsidised fertiliser (September 2026).

Every core government transaction system the GovTech Maturity Index assesses for Egypt is recorded as in use — financial management, treasury, tax administration, customs, human resources, payroll, social insurance, debt management and e-procurement — and the national public service portal is transactional rather than informational, so front office and back office alike sit at the index's upper bands (2025).

The payroll system was live in 2,281 of 2,675 target accounting units in February 2024, calculating wage tax and insurance contributions electronically.

The systems themselves are mostly bought in: the financial management information system runs on commercial off-the-shelf software, and tax administration and customs are both hybrids of custom and off-the-shelf products (2025). The practitioner account is less tidy: practitioners told Al-Borsa that some tax offices still work from paper files during inspection before entering results on the system, and that historic credit balances have not been carried into it (July 2026), though the same portal carries the e-invoicing system mandatory since December 2022.

The health ministry launched DHIS2 as part of its national health information system in January 2026, in support of the National Digital Health Strategic Priorities 2025-2029. Separately, primary healthcare centres and units in the governorates where the Universal Health Insurance System applies are fully digitised, with electronic health records and electronic prescriptions (2024).

Elsewhere the systems work inside their own walls. The interior and communications ministries run an integrated Digital Justice Platform whose police-station module issues complaints and records electronically into the Public Prosecution's paperless case management, extended to 118 police departments by late 2025. Agriculture's systems are a farmer smart card for fertiliser, pesticide and seed quotas, introduced in 2016, and the Hudhud AI pest-identification app of 2021 (2024). And the irrigation ministry's planned integrated water system is to allow data exchange between the ministry's own sectors, the minister having ordered an assessment of the models and databases each sector holds so they can be developed or merged into it (July 2026).

Other GovTech and e-Gov

Egypt ranked 22nd on the World Bank's 2025 GovTech Maturity Index, up from 69th in 2022 on a score of 0.911, while placing 95th of 193 states on the UN's 2024 E-Government Development Index.

Launched in 2020, the Digital Egypt platform had 10.7 million registered users and 210 services at the start of January 2026, about 20 million transactions in 2026 to July, and about 250 services in September 2026, against targets of 270 by the end of 2026 and 400 by 2030; transactions rose from 7.8 million in 2024 to more than 25 million in 2025, with 73 services offered exclusively on the platform and other digital channels.

The state is closing the paper counter behind it. Nine commercial-registry services became available exclusively through Digital Egypt from 1 January 2026, and GAFI's investment e-licensing platform offers 460 services from 41 government issuers; limited liability companies have been incorporated only on GAFI's portal, with an electronic-signature token, since 3 August 2025, and powers of attorney, notarisation lookups and notary-office booking are on Digital Egypt, though some transactions still need an office visit (October 2026). In July 2026 the local development and communications ministries launched public-shop licensing on the platform, using the digital treasury, making it the first government service to reuse verified digital documents from the treasury.

Citizen-facing services are narrower than the totals suggest. The Public Prosecution's electronic enquiry returns only judgments held on its own system and registered against the enquirer's own national number, and its result is stated not to substitute for official certificates or extracts. Cairo airport was to begin trial issuing of visas on arrival as a QR code from 1 August 2026, valid seven days, with paper running in parallel for a transition, and the digital channel carries an issuance fee on top of the visa fee, so the switch is monetised rather than absorbed. The justice

ministry's E-Court platform went live for first-instance criminal courts on 31 August 2026, charging lawyers EGP 500 a year, EGP 500 for each remote felony hearing and EGP 10 a page for certified case-file copies, fees the Lawyers Syndicate says have no legal basis. Where a service needs a decision, the counter reappears: flagging an unrecognised mobile line in the My NTRA app cannot cancel or transfer it, and the citizen must still attend the carrier in person with the physical card.

E-procurement is in use and publishes tender notices and awarded contracts (2025), as Law 182 of 2018 requires public entities to publish their plans, tenders and awards on the Public Procurement Portal. The gaps are in delivery: the 95 online social-insurance services promised in February 2026 within six months were still to come in August 2026, a first phase of 40 announced as forthcoming, leaving employers attending insurance offices in person across the authority's roughly 170 services until they move online. In September 2026 the deputy finance minister heading the Real Estate Tax Authority acknowledged failures in the newly launched property-tax app, attributing them to traffic from some 1.2 million users against an expected 10 million registrations, and said an extension of the filing deadline was under review, the authority working round the clock with the contractor that built the app. In October a ministry source said the electricity holding company had switched off its unified customer platform for an untested replacement, leaving distribution companies unable to see citizens' requests, and the electricity minister ordered the fault fixed. Ration cards went the other way: heads of household can now update card data, replace or activate cards and transfer files between governorates on Digital Egypt, the data-update service piloted in Port Said for three months (October 2026).

Digitalisation

Digitalisation of sub-national government

A licensing regime the governorates administer moved onto the national platform in July 2026, when the Ministry of Local Development and MCIT launched public-shop licensing on Digital Egypt, using the digital treasury. Fees were unified across the participating agencies, the Interior Ministry cutting its own by half, and a single back-office body was given a binding maximum approval time. The enforcement half went with it: the penalties of Public Shops Law 154 of 2019 are to be applied to unlicensed premises and licence breaches, with governorate agencies canvassing commercial premises and mobile technology vans taking applications on site. The service is the first of more government services due to use the digital treasury.

The plumbing beneath it does reach below the national level. A 2025 ministry project standardised digital applications across the governorates and integrated key citizen- and investor-facing ones into the Digital Egypt platform, and the financial management information system, commercial off-the-shelf, is in extensive use across central and sub-national government alike (2025). The direction of travel is now back down the same wires: under the FY2026/27 development plan the integrated population databases are used to assess each governorate's performance on the population file, with incentives tied to the result (2026).

One governorate publishes its own account. Cairo Governorate says it has digitised real-estate tax, citizen complaints, building-violation reconciliation, cemetery and parking reservations, vacancy announcements, tenders and auctions, and announced a unified kiosk system across the city, and on 13 October 2026 it launched a six-month programme for its citizen service centre staff to produce a unified service guide, a complaint-handling checklist and service-evaluation indicators.

Rural digital data capture

The agriculture ministry has linked about 8 million feddans of farmland to its electronic agricultural-holdings system, surveying and mapping the land so that each plot carries a unique identification number (September 2026).

Fibre had reached more than 1,250 of the 1,450 villages targeted by the Decent Life programme by mid-2026, some five million lines laid across 20 governorates, and the build has accelerated year on year — 267 villages by the end of 2023, 856 by the end of 2024 and past a thousand during 2025. The Ministry of Communications and Information Technology restated the village figure after talks with the World Bank in July 2026 and named Decent Life as the vehicle for its rural connectivity work; 1,367 mobile towers had gone up in its villages under the same programme (2023), and rules for licensing and pricing renewable mini-grids intended for remote communities were adopted in 2025.

Fewer than 200 of the targeted villages were still without fibre by mid-2026.

What runs over the connection has moved more slowly. Clinic-level digitisation under the health insurance system — electronic health records and e-prescribing across primary care units — has been completed in the governorates where that system applies rather than nationally (2024), and police documents were often still handwritten, many police stations lacking computers outside parts of Cairo and Alexandria (2021). The digitised agricultural systems that do reach farmers are a smart card showing each holding's fertiliser, pesticide and seed quotas and an AI pest-identification app (2024). Ration-card grievances and data updates are still taken over the counter at post offices (July 2026).

The rural economy those systems describe has barely shifted. Egypt's rural economy score rose 0.8 points over 2014–2023, to 67.8 of 100 and 15th of 54 African states (2023), and within it land and water access is the strongest component at 77.3 and eighth in Africa while rural representation and participation is the weakest at 60.7 and thirty-third, market access having fallen 3.0 points over the decade (2023). The national strategy itself names a digital divide across geographical regions, with digital infrastructure weakest in remote areas, which the village build is meant to close.

Technology

AI

Egypt's telecommunications regulator has a unit in operation that detects and acts on AI-manipulated video and imagery circulating on social platforms (July 2026), and the ICT minister told a ministerial meeting the same month that legislative amendment is needed to confront such content at root. Nothing has been enacted to close the gap: in August 2026 the Communications Committee's deputy chair was still arguing that the existing IT-crimes law needs limited amendment rather than new legislation, and pointing to watermarking of AI-generated images and video as the course taken elsewhere.

Elsewhere what runs is sectoral: agriculture's Hudhud app uses AI to help farmers identify and treat pests (2024), and the first clearances into live testing in the financial regulator's sandbox include an insurer's remote motor-damage assessment (August 2026). In the government exchange layer the record is of memoranda rather than systems: MCIT and its IT industry agency signed memoranda with IBM on generative AI for government institutions and with Huawei on AI capabilities (2023).

The state's own AI building is the Applied Innovation Centre's Arabic large language model, Karnak, and a responsible-AI centre, ECRAI, set up at the ministry at the end of 2025; in August 2026 the minister said Karnak tops international evaluation platforms among Arabic models in its 30-billion and 40-billion parameter classes, and the ministry launched a chat service built on it in pilot, run from Egyptian data centres. The minister presents Karnak alongside the Applied Innovation Centre's work converting research into applications for state and society, and AI in early disease detection (August 2026), leaning on the university skilling pipeline and the giant data-centre build-out the ICT ministry presented to Cabinet in July 2026.

The paper architecture is now two strategies deep. A Second National Artificial Intelligence Strategy was adopted in 2025 on six pillars, following the National Council for AI of 2019, the first strategy of 2021 and the Responsible AI Charter of 2023, and the council's remit has been widened to take in quantum computing and emerging technologies alongside AI. At a meeting reported on 25 September 2026 the council adopted the first-half 2026 progress report on the second strategy, reviewed the outlines of a National Quantum Computing Strategy 2027–2030 and discussed guidelines on government AI procurement, generative AI in government and children's use of AI. Regionally Egypt chairs the Arab AI Governance Working Group, whose task is to activate an Arab Charter for AI Ethics that describes itself as advisory and expressly not a substitute for national policy or binding regulation.

Bilateral work repeats the pattern: the water minister's August 2026 agreements with Japan name AI and digital models for monitoring water structures and reducing flood risk, with no money, named system or implementation date attached. A newspaper reported that Egypt led the Human Rights Council to adopt by consensus a resolution on artificial intelligence and human rights.

ICT Industry

The communications ministry has set targets of $8bn of digital exports by 2028, $12bn of outsourcing exports by 2029 and 120 electronics-design companies by 2030, against $7.4bn of digital exports and more than 86 design companies in 2025 (September 2026); outsourcing exports in 2025 were about double the $2.4bn of 2022.

The state's industrial pitch places Egypt as the delivery location rather than the vendor. EY MENA has agreed with ITIDA to establish a regional IT outsourcing delivery centre in the country (July 2026); Konecta has opened a Cairo regional headquarters together with a generative-AI centre of excellence (July 2026); Egypt's ICT minister and the British ambassador discussed in January 2026 widening ICT cooperation and drawing British firms into Egypt's offshoring industry, pitching Egypt as a regional hub and gateway to African markets; and cooperation with SAP on cloud, AI and outsourcing was deepened in March 2026. What these arrangements sell is Egyptian labour and Egyptian floor space to firms headquartered elsewhere.

Underneath sits a domestic sector of real size. Fawry is the country's largest mobile money platform, serving nearly half the population, and the developer population counted on the main code-hosting platform is large and growing quickly (2024). Ownership of the infrastructure layer is moving towards the state rather than away from it: Telecom Egypt cancelled the sale of a stake in its Regional Data Center Hub and will instead carve the estate out as a wholly-owned subsidiary (July 2026), an entity its chief executive said in October had been established, keeping it inside a majority state-owned operator.

Government technology spending reaches domestic suppliers through a programme to support GovTech startups and public-private arrangements for delivering online public services (2025), though neither the programme nor any of the partnerships is named in the record.

Innovation ecosystem

Egypt is North Africa's leading startup market, with US$524m of venture funding raised in the second half of 2025 to the end of November, and the year's notable exit was GlobalFoundries' acquisition of the Egyptian chip-design startup InfiniLink — a hardware exit in a market whose money mostly goes to fintech.

The state's financing instrument is the Egypt Startup Charter, which attaches a headline EGP 50bn to a target of 5,000 startups (December 2025). Private capital has been arriving for longer than the charter has existed: Partech counted around US$297m of equity funding into Egyptian tech startups in 2024, one of Africa's top four venture destinations and second by number of deals.

The supporting institutions are dense. A commercial directory listed 39 accelerators and incubators in January 2025, with the African Development Bank's mapping identifying dozens more university-based incubators, including 48 supported by the Academy of Scientific Research and Technology.

Absorption is the weaker half. The financial regulator's sandbox has produced far more advisory guidance to firms than it has authorisations, with only its first projects reaching live testing (August 2026). Government has both a public sector innovation strategy and a programme, with an established innovation lab working on digital skills and public service innovation (2025), and its open source software policy is advisory rather than mandatory (2025), which limits how far public procurement can be a route in for domestic developers. On the outside measure, Egypt ranked 86th in the WIPO Global Innovation Index 2024, within a confidence interval of 82nd to 88th.

Capacity

Literacy

Egypt is near the top of Africa for getting children through school and near the bottom for doing it evenly: Education Completion reached 94.2 of 100 and fifth of 54 African states in 2023, up 14.7 points over the decade, with Education Quality up 15.9 points to 55.2 and Enrolment up 5.5 points to 56.8, while over the same ten years Equality in Education fell 1.1 points to 35.1 of 100, 44th of 54 (2023). The weakest of Egypt's education measures is the one that says who the gains reached.

The teaching base thinned as the intake grew. Human Resources in Education is among the ten most deteriorated Ibrahim Index indicators for Egypt, down 11.3 points over 2014–2023 to 86.2 of 100 and 25th of 54 — high in absolute terms, and falling while completion climbed.

The digital floor inside the classroom is uneven in the same direction. Primary schools share devices far more thinly than secondary and technical ones, so day-to-day attendance and record-keeping is still done on paper before it is aggregated into the education MIS (2025), even though the great majority of Egypt's schools now meet the Ministry of Education's "smart school" criteria. Outside school, the same floor is what the payments push keeps meeting: low digital financial literacy is named alongside entrenched cash habits and fraud exposure as a brake on digital payment adoption (July 2026).

Training and skills

The MCIT/Dell "AI Capacity Building Initiative for Universities" has trained 2,710 students and produced 763 projects cumulatively since 2022, and its fourth round closed on 4 August 2026 with 1,090 students from ten public, private and national universities delivering 445 projects across smart agriculture, smart traffic, smart government, digital healthcare and the smart economy. A parallel hackathon on new and renewable energy under the same initiative drew 105 students in 21 teams from ten universities, ten teams reaching the final, and under a tripartite agreement AstraZeneca Egypt supplied healthcare datasets so that students worked on real data.

No cost, no funding split between the ministry and Dell, no placement or employment outcome for any cohort, and no account of what became of the 763 projects has been published (August 2026).

The volume is in the communications ministry's own programmes: its Digital Egypt Generations initiatives trained more than 156,000 people in 2025, from about 70,000 primary pupils to 24,000 university students and graduates, and about 277,000 since launch, on the ministry's account. Beneath the AI programmes, the state trains its own. Egypt has both a digital skills strategy and a digital skills programme for the public service, free to take and extending as far as advanced data science and deep learning (2025). The pipeline feeding it is narrow: ICT graduates are around 10.5 percent of Egypt's tertiary graduates and STEM graduates around 20.8 percent, with Egypt 79th of 123

countries on the Global Knowledge Index ICT sub-index (2021). Absorption is being sought abroad rather than at home: talks with the United Kingdom in January 2026 pitched Egypt's offshoring industry and talent pool to British firms, with Egypt as a regional hub and gateway to African markets.

Training reaches beyond software. The National Telecommunications Institute runs a free cybersecurity academy with EG-CERT and vendor partners across the governorates (July 2026), and Egypt has looked to Japan's water-related disaster centre for training Egyptian engineers on flood forecast models and risk maps (August 2026). The communications and labour ministries signed a memorandum to digitise the labour ministry's work and run digital-skills programmes for its staff, graduates and job seekers (2026).

Research institutions

The Applied Innovation Centre has built an Arabic large language model called "Karnak", and a responsible-AI centre, ECRAI, was set up at the end of 2025. The ICT minister places these alongside the university AI pipeline and the Applied Innovation Centre, describing the centre's work as converting research into applications for the state and society and naming Karnak beside AI in early disease detection (August 2026) — the ministry's own account of one effort running from student projects to a national model.

The institutional base under it is broad. Tracxn's directory listed 39 accelerators and incubators in Egypt as of January 2025, and the African Development Bank's mapping identifies dozens more university-based incubators, 48 of them supported by the Academy of Scientific Research and Technology. Output ranks lower than the institutional count suggests: Egypt placed 86th in the WIPO Global Innovation Index 2024, within a confidence interval of 82nd to 88th.

Inclusion

Access to services

Egypt's Equal Access to Public Services score is unchanged over 2014–2023 at 42.5 of 100, 24th of 54 African states: a decade of service reform has not shifted how equally services reach different groups.

What has changed is obligation. In December 2024 the National Telecom Regulatory Authority extended accessibility requirements to mobile e-wallet services, requiring accessible app interfaces, sign-language interpreters and Braille contracts, on top of an earlier 50% discount on mobile packages for people with disabilities, alongside Central Bank instructions under which banks offer sign-language service by video call, screen-reader-compatible channels, Braille forms and ATMs with Braille keypads, with fee-free, no-minimum-balance account opening on an annual inclusion day.

The counter has not gone away. Ration-card grievances and data updates run through 500 post offices (July 2026), making Egypt Post the physical desk for ministry digital services; the social insurance authority still has employers attending its offices in person while its services wait to move online (August 2026); and flagging an unrecognised mobile line in the regulator's app still ends with a visit to the carrier and the physical ID card (August 2026). Universal health insurance enrolment requires photo ID for every family member over 16 and, as at June 2024, ran in the first-phase governorates only.

Non-nationals are served on a parallel track. Egypt's Civil Status Law has health offices receive notifications of the births and deaths of foreign nationals living in the country, and refugees and asylum-seekers are handled by the system though the law does not name them (2025). Around 16 percent of Egypt's refugee population receives UNHCR's monthly multi-purpose cash grants through Egypt Post (2025).

Financial inclusion stands at 72.5 percent for women and 58 percent for Egyptians aged 15 to 35 as at June 2026, women's rate having climbed faster than the national headline since 2016.

Digital divides

Mobile phone ownership in Egypt is close to parity between men and women, yet 65 percent of men and 54 percent of women use mobile internet (2023): an eleven-point gap sitting on top of near-identical handset ownership, so the line runs through use rather than through owning the device.

The service measures move the other way. Egypt's Access to Public Services for Women score rose 9.7 points over 2014–2023 to 44.9 of 100, 25th of 54 African states, and Socioeconomic Opportunity for Women rose 17.5 points to 64.1, 10th of 54 — among the strongest decade movements anywhere in Egypt's record.

Geography is the divide the state names itself: Egypt Vision 2030 names a digital divide across geographical regions, with digital infrastructure weakest in remote areas (2023). It is not a divide in basic utilities — electricity reaches effectively the whole population (2023), with no gap between town and country (2016) — and the Decent Life fibre and mobile-tower programme has been building village connections since, with Telecom Egypt's laying of lines still short of the target village count as at June 2026.

Inside the school system the divide is by stage. Egyptian primary schools average 95 students to each shared digital device, against close to one-to-one ratios in secondary and technical education (2025), so day-to-day attendance and record-keeping in primary schools is still taken on paper before it reaches the education management system. That sits alongside equality in education, the weakest of Egypt's education measures and slightly worse in 2023 than a decade earlier, even as internet and computer access has been among its most improved indicators of any kind. Coverage has risen faster than the evenness of its distribution.

Data

National statistics

Egypt's 2027 population, housing and establishments census is designed to match a full electronic field count against state digital records, building central statistical registers of buildings and units, households, individuals and establishments — and the presidential decree authorising it was still pending as at 20 July 2026, waiting on a property-wealth map and a secure electronic data exchange that must both be finalised first. The government means to hold the cost down through self-enumeration, state staff, reuse of tablets and activated data exchange between agencies, and MCIT is to certify the system, data-centre and security specifications the exercise will run on.

The survey programme behind that shift is uneven. A population census and a business census had been run within the ten years to 2023, while the most recent agricultural census fell in the decade before that; over the same period Egypt ran three or more household, labour force and health surveys and two agricultural surveys, but no business or establishment survey at all. On the same measures, data use scores above 89%, with data services, data products, data sources and data infrastructure all in the 70–89% band (2023).

Egypt scores 70.1 of 100 for the capacity of its statistical system (2023), seventh of 54 African states, a score that has slipped a point over the decade. The same profile leaves its public-perception indicators unscored for Egypt, so the governance record carries no citizen-reported layer at all.

Administrative data is being asked to do more. The FY2026/27 development plan expands integrated databases that allow population indicators to be followed in real time, with the same base tracking fertility, early marriage and contraceptive uptake and the results used to assess governorate performance and tie incentives to what each

governorate achieves on the population file. The planning ministry has also launched a platform ranking all 27 governorates against their 2030 sustainable development targets on official statistics (July 2025). The statistics agency publishes a metadata catalogue of its surveys and datasets, with view counts per dataset.

Open data

Egypt adopted its first National Open Data Policy in August 2025, as a transitional framework pending a data governance law — but there is still no right to ask for what the state does not choose to publish, the right to information law remaining in draft with consultations in progress (2025).

That asymmetry is visible in the scores. Disclosure of Public Records rose 13.3 points over 2014–2023 to 34.0 of 100, 25th of 54 African states, while Accessibility of Public Records stands at 18.7 of 100 and 41st of 54, up only 4.2 points across the same decade: what the state elects to publish has improved several times faster than what a citizen can obtain on request. Accountability and Transparency, at 19.2 of 100 and 45th of 54 in 2023, slipped slightly over the decade even as the overall governance score rose.

On the 2024 Open Data Inventory the economic series come out best, national accounts, balance of payments, government finance, trade, labour and banking statistics each scoring 6 out of 10 for openness and coverage, and prices 5. The social series are weaker and far more uneven — population 6, education outcomes 5, gender statistics 4, health facilities 4, food security 3.5, and poverty and health outcomes 3 apiece — while environmental data sits in a narrow band, agriculture at 5.5 down to the built environment and pollution at 4.5.

Delivery runs ahead of the rules. Egypt operates a government open data portal carrying a comprehensive data catalogue and updated weekly or daily, though the publication process behind it is mostly manual, and the e-procurement system publishes both tender notices and awarded contracts (2025). Where publication is discretionary it thins quickly: only the original 2021 rules for the instant payment network are on the central bank's site, the current iterations going to participating banks alone.

Much of the documentation behind Egypt's government digital systems is recorded in the 2025 GovTech Maturity Index as existing but internal and unpublished, across most of its indicator families.

Use of satellite data

The agriculture ministry monitors the farmland linked to its electronic holdings system, about 8 million feddans, for encroachment by satellite imagery (September 2026).

Reception is domestic: a station receiving Sentinel-1, -2 and -3 data, gifted by the African Union and the European Union, was installed at the national remote sensing authority in January 2022, and the Meteorological Authority lists Meteosat Second Generation reception among its training facilities (2014). In water management the irrigation ministry said in August 2026 that it intends to draw on Japan's GSMaP satellite rainfall product to monitor rainfall across Nile Basin states, and to sharpen hydrological forecasting, soil-moisture estimates and estimates of what agriculture actually needs. In land administration the National Real Estate Identification System resolves each property's digital identifier through a land, building, unit and street hierarchy (2025), and the Egyptian Survey Authority's cadastral mapping is linked to the digital property registry.

Geopolitics

US / hyperscaler activities

American infrastructure in Egypt runs through the cable layer: Telecom Egypt and Cisco partnered in January 2025 to operate subsea capacity on the Mediterranean segment of the 2Africa cable system, and Egypt is a transit hub on that system, whose consortium includes Meta alongside European, Chinese and African operators. Inside the state's own systems the American presence is at the memorandum stage, the communications ministry having signed a memorandum of understanding with IBM on generative artificial intelligence for government institutions (2023), and at the letter-of-intent stage with Cisco, which signed with the communications ministry on 1 September 2026 to explore scaling AI across government and priority sectors, with no value or term stated.

China activities

Huawei Cloud opened a public cloud region in Cairo in May 2024, on a five-year investment of 300 million US dollars. The same partnership reaches into the retail network, where Telecom Egypt's consumer arm and Huawei launched fibre-to-the-room commercially in May 2026, the first such service in the country, and into finance, where Huawei used a Cairo fintech summit in June 2026, with the chief executive of the brokerage Thndr among the panellists, to pitch locally hosted cloud, artificial intelligence and data-management services at fintech firms, start-ups included. In government the relationship stands where the American one does: the communications ministry's IT industry agency has a memorandum of understanding with Huawei on artificial intelligence capabilities (2023). During the Chinese president's visit in September 2026 the communications minister signed a memorandum on technological and digital cooperation covering cloud computing, data centres, the data economy, semiconductors and cybersecurity, whose text is not published, and Huawei has bid to build the government's AI data centres, against a rival consortium the US State Department is assembling (August 2026). China Mobile also sits in the 2Africa consortium, giving Chinese carriers a stake in the cable that lands on Egypt's coast as well as in the cloud region and the access network above it.

EU activities

Cloud cooperation Egypt discussed with SAP in March 2026 was aimed at its digital sovereignty over data and applications hosted on SAP platforms; it came as Egypt and SAP deepened cooperation on cloud, artificial intelligence and outsourcing, adding a European vendor track to the cloud estate alongside the Chinese one. The Netherlands is the counterpart on water, where the irrigation ministry is developing an integrated digital system for forecasting, managing and distributing water under phase two of the JCAR 2 applied research programme run with the Dutch side (July 2026). The oldest European position is in hardware: the French vendor IDEMIA has held recurring contracts for biometric device production in partnership with the local firm AOI, leaving the identity estate reliant on a foreign supplier for its biometric devices even as assembly happens in Egypt.

Gulf/UAE activities

The Central Bank of Egypt enabled instant inbound cross-border remittances in December 2024, letting recipients take funds straight into bank accounts or wallets through the Instant Payment Network, with further bilateral links planned to Jordan, Saudi Arabia and the UAE. The Gulf's place in those rails is therefore a set of planned connections rather than working ones. Its technology capital is on record too: an Emirati operator and an Egyptian group agreed a US$250m, 25 MW hyperscale data centre at Maadi Technology Park in 2023, with no construction on record, and Abu Dhabi's sovereign investor co-led a US$35m round in the Egyptian-founded payments company Paymob in September 2026, for its expansion across the region.

India activities

Egypt's and India's industry ministers discussed, on the sidelines of the BRICS industry ministers' meeting in Jaipur on 7 August 2026, linking their payment systems and settling trade in local currencies to cut transfer costs.

Digital sovereignty

Egypt needs US permission to import AI chips while it weighs a Chinese offer for its government AI data centres: AI chip shipments to Egypt have needed American permission since 2023, and Huawei's tender for those data centres offers 1,408 Ascend 950-series chips for a training cloud and 600 more for two inference clusters on a 12-month build (August 2026).

The hosting policy allows state data on either side of the border: the World Bank's 2025 GovTech index records Egypt's government-cloud hosting policy as hybrid, inside and outside the country. Decisions are being taken system by system. The Rashid register of state-owned companies is to run on e-Finance's hosting servers, secure storage and computing under a protocol with the Cabinet's State-Owned Enterprises Unit (July 2026), and President El-Sisi directed in August 2026 that the highest standards of cybersecurity and digital sovereignty be applied to litigants' data in the City of Justice digital-court project.

The payment rails are majority-owned by the central bank: the Egyptian Banks Company, which develops and operates the national payments infrastructure including InstaPay, is 54% owned by the central bank (2025). The terms on which the Huawei Cloud region, the September 2026 Egypt–China digital memorandum and the Vodafone–Cassava sovereign AI data centre govern data jurisdiction, portability and exit had not been published as at September 2026.

The state's own model is built on open foundations: Karnak was made by retraining the latest global open-source models on published Egyptian and Arab data, with running inside Egyptian data centres named as its first objective (August 2026). Regionally, the communications ministry took AI governance, digital sovereignty and data protection to the Arab AI summit in Hammamet on 7-10 September 2026.

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